

# AI-ready metadata in practice

Lessons from building Portolan

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# Who is talking

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 Based in Seville, Spain

 Twenty-plus years in the geospatial industry

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### THIS TALK

slides [cayetanobv.github.io/ogc-metadata-summit-bolzano](https://cayetanobv.github.io/ogc-metadata-summit-bolzano)

catalog [github.com/cayetanobv/south-tyrol-geodata-portolan-mirror](https://github.com/cayetanobv/south-tyrol-geodata-portolan-mirror)

project [portolan-sdi.org](https://portolan-sdi.org)

# What Portolan is

Portolan is an **open specification with an open-source toolkit** that combines **cloud-native file formats** with **clear metadata** and **documentation** so that **people and agents** can publish and use data **at any scale**.



## specification and toolkit

spec v0.2.0 · `portolan`  
CLI · `rashid` validator ·  
a registry of catalogs



## cloud-native file formats

GeoParquet for vector ·  
COG for raster · PMTiles  
for display



## clear metadata

a STAC 1.1 publishing  
profile: what a catalog  
must contain



## documentation

`README.md` for people ·  
`AGENTS.md` for agents,  
at every level



## people and agents, any scale

ten agent skills · from a  
city's open data to a 369  
TB archive

# Why Portolan: the same goals as any SDI, a lighter way to deliver them

SAME VISION · A FEDERATED SPATIAL DATA INFRASTRUCTURE, DISCOVERABLE, INTEROPERABLE, OPENLY ACCESSIBLE TO ALL



## AI-ready

TODAY

SDIs were not built for agents. Agents need full data and rich metadata, fast.

INSTEAD

**Agents are first-class readers.**



## Easy to implement

TODAY

Database, WFS, WMS, schemas, specialist staff. Most organisations cannot take part.

INSTEAD

**Files in a bucket.**



## Scalable

TODAY

Agents crawl whole datasets. Popularity means more servers, until something breaks.

INSTEAD

**Scales with nobody on call.**



## Low cost

TODAY

Servers always on, ops engineers, a traffic spike is an emergency.

INSTEAD

**Storage and egress.**



## Sovereign

TODAY

Dependence on foreign clouds and vendors.

INSTEAD

**The full stack in your jurisdiction.**

Two decades of SDI work got the hard part right: models, catalogues, INSPIRE themes, ISO records. What changed is the delivery layer underneath. Your catalogues and records stay authoritative.

# You already know the stack. Most of it carries an OGC stamp.

| Piece                      | Role in a Portolan catalog                                                                       | Status                                          |
|----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| STAC 1.1                   | catalog · collection · item · asset, plus the provider, table, file and web-map-links extensions | OGC Community Standard<br>Oct 2025              |
| GeoJSON                    | every STAC Item is a GeoJSON Feature                                                             | IETF RFC 7946                                   |
| Cloud Optimized GeoTIFF    | raster, with overviews, read by range requests                                                   | OGC Standard<br>2023                            |
| GeoParquet                 | vector: Parquet with Simple Features geometry                                                    | OGC Standards Working Group<br>approval pending |
| PMTiles                    | tiles in one file, for map display                                                               | community format<br>outside OGC                 |
| Zarr · COPC                | multidimensional arrays · point clouds<br>planned, not shipped                                   | Zarr: OGC Community Standard<br>2022            |
| HTTP range requests · CORS | read straight from object storage; the only server involved is the storage itself                | IETF · WHATWG                                   |

Nothing here is new.



# STAC describes the data. Portolan defines how it is published.

STAC 1.1.0 BASELINE + PORTOLAN v0.2.0 PROFILE



DESCRIBES + LINKS

Catalog → Collection → Item → Asset

same STAC objects



PORTOLAN

v0.2.0 · pre-1.0

**PROFILES THE PUBLICATION**

opinionated · versioned · checkable

THE PROFILE MAKES SIX PUBLISHING CHOICES EXPLICIT



STRUCTURE + LINKS



FORMATS + STATISTICS



ACCESS + HOSTING



LICENSE + PROVENANCE



README + AGENTS

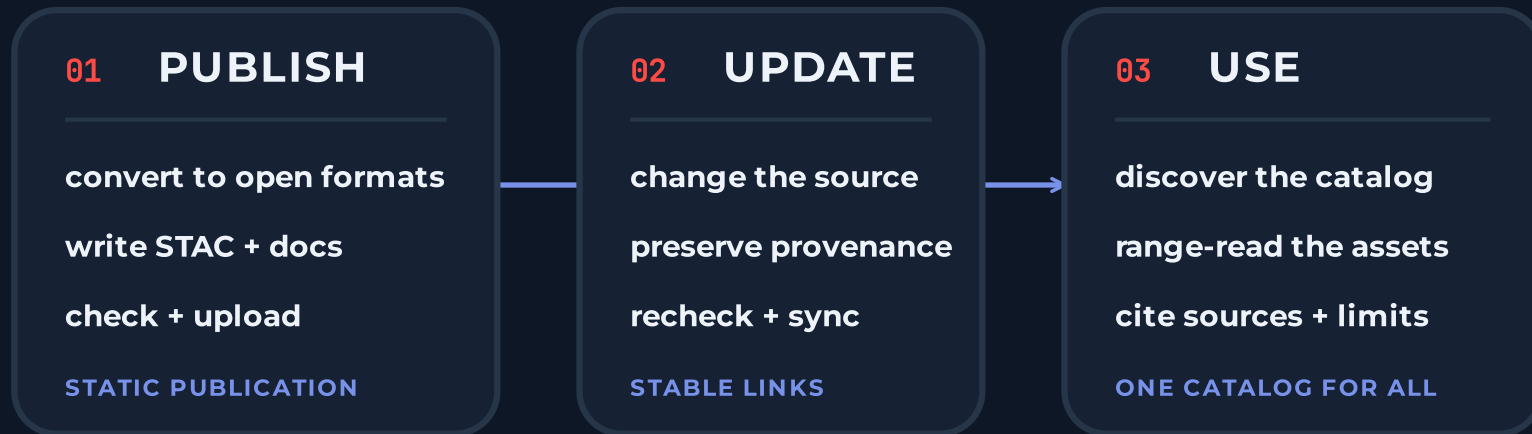


VISUALIZATION

[schemas.portolan-sdi.org/portolan/v0.2.0/schema.json](https://schemas.portolan-sdi.org/portolan/v0.2.0/schema.json)

# Portolan connects the pieces: publish · update · use

ONE PRACTICE ACROSS THE DATA LIFECYCLE



**PORTOLAN**

STAC 1.1 · GeoParquet · COG · PMTiles · HTTP · object storage  
opinionated · checkable · no new data format · nothing replaced

AI-READY

EASY TO  
IMPLEMENT

SCALABLE

LOW COST

SOVEREIGN

# What Portolan adds: four things the standards leave open, made mandatory



## A quality floor you can check

bbox columns and spatial order in every GeoParquet ·  
overviews in every COG · providers and licence on every  
collection · range requests and CORS on the host. `rashid`  
reads the bytes, not just the JSON.



## Two documents at every level

`README.md` for the person deciding whether to trust the  
data · `AGENTS.md` for the agent that needs the join key and  
the caveats.



## No server in the request path

a folder in storage the publisher controls · cost is storage  
and egress · nothing runs after publishing.



## Federation without a central copy

a registry of independently hosted catalogs, plain JSON in  
version control · producer, provider and host named on  
each.

DOES A STATIC MODEL SCALE? FIELDS OF THE WORLD, ONE PORTOLAN CATALOG ON SOURCE COOPERATIVE

# 369 TB

published

# 106.6 TB

served in the 28 days to 27 August 2026

# 0

servers in front of it

Data: Fields of the World ([fieldsoftheworld.com](https://fieldsoftheworld.com)), published on Source Cooperative; figures from the Portolan launch post, 2 Sep 2026.



# Story 1 · A mirror of this province's open data, published as a spec v0.2.0 catalog in five commands

```
# 1. Pull 69 of the 207 layers of South Tyrol's WFS (~12 min)
portolan extract wfs $BZ_WFS ./bz --license CC0-1.0 \
  --layers "p_bz-Health:*,p_bz-Hydrology:Watercourses,..."

# 2. Validate against the spec
portolan check
# x PTL-PRV-001 no provider carries the 'producer' role (x69)

# 3. Who produced it, who hosts it, what it is not; 11 themes
$EDITOR .portolan/metadata.yaml

# 4. Regenerate STAC + README + AGENTS.md, re-check
portolan add --force . && portolan readme
portolan check --fix && rashid check . --schema --data
# 0 error(s), 0 warning(s) across 81 files

# 5. Push to a public bucket (Milan). Nothing else runs.
portolan push gs://south-tyrol-geodata-portolan-mirror/
rashid check . --live --live-base-url $PUBLIC_URL
# 0 error(s): range requests, CORS, sizes honoured
```

**The service seeded what it could.** Titles in three languages, keywords, abstracts, styles from the WMS. 69 layers to GeoParquet, spatially ordered, bbox column added; PMTiles and thumbnails alongside.

**The validator failed on the machine contract**, not on the prose: no producer, no license from the service. The producer's knowledge went into YAML at every level; from it came `README.md`, `collection.json`, `AGENTS.md`.

**Two validators, same answer: conforms to v0.2.0**, hosting contract included once pushed (range requests, CORS, sizes). The same run, hands off: an agent with the `portolan-bootstrap` skill does steps 1–5 and writes the documentation. No server was started. The result is a folder in a bucket.

EXAMPLE CATALOG [open it in the Portolan browser ↗](#) · [catalog.json on storage.googleapis.com ↗](#) · [metadata and CI on GitHub ↗](#)

Data: Provincia Autonoma di Bolzano – Alto Adige / Autonome Provinz Bozen – Südtirol (Ripartizione 28 · ASTAT · Ripartizione 23 Salute), CC0 1.0, via [data.civis.bz.it](https://data.civis.bz.it) and the provincial WFS. Community mirror extracted 5 September 2026 — not an official publication; the authoritative source is the Province's geoportal.

# Where the metadata comes from: measured, harvested, asserted

DECLARED IN `metadata.yaml` · one file per level

catalog root · 1 file  
license · contact · providers  
attribution · keywords · citations

inherits

themes · 11 files  
title · description

inherits

collections · 69 files  
description · keywords · source\_url  
processing\_notes · license\_url  
title · known\_issues

81

`metadata.yaml` files, one per level

1

carries the licence, contact and providers for all 69 collections

HARVESTED · extract / agent

WFS · CSW · portal page  
abstract · keywords · URL  
"TODO: Add value" if none  
drafted into **YAML**, reviewed

MEASURED FROM THE DATA · `portolan add`, every run

`rest-homes.parquet`  
extent.spatial.bbox  
CRS · `geoparquet:geometry_type`  
table:row\_count  
table:columns, names + types  
file:size · file:checksum  
stac\_extensions · as found

re-read on every add:  
the record cannot drift  
from the file it describes

portolan add

`collection.json` · `README.md` · `AGENTS.md`

drafted by a tool · approved by a person · gated by rashid · check in CI on every push

# Story 2 · Then an agent was asked a question no single layer answers

*"Which hospitals and pharmacies in South Tyrol sit inside high or very-high hydraulic hazard zones of the approved hazard-zone plans, and how many residents live in those municipalities?"*

**4 of 17**

hospitals inside H3/H4 zones · Bolzano, Bressanone, Brunico, Ortisei

**31 of 158**

pharmacies inside H3/H4 zones · Merano 3, Bolzano 2, Bressanone 2, Brunico 2 ...

**108 of 116**

municipalities with an approved hydraulic hazard plan · 536,933 residents in the province

STATED BY THE AGENT, BECAUSE THE PUBLISHER WROTE IT DOWN

Points are locations, not service catchments. Hazard classes are planning zones, not event forecasts. Eight municipalities have no approved plan yet. Producer: Autonomous Province of Bolzano – South Tyrol · CC0-1.0 · query attached.

WHAT IT HAD TO WORK WITH

- 69 collections in 11 themes, `AGENTS.md` at every level
- the join key `ISTAT_CODE`, the CRS, the H2–H4 class strings, the caveats
- GeoParquet with bbox columns, read in place with DuckDB
- the `reading-portoLan` skill: how to navigate, query, join and report

WHAT IT DID NOT HAVE

- a server, an API, credentials, or a person in the loop

A screening, not a risk assessment. The same catalog answers the next question tomorrow.

# What the agent actually did with the metadata

1

## Open `catalog.json`

follow the explicit child links: 11 theme catalogs, 69 collections; the linked graph is the publication boundary

2

## Read `AGENTS.md`

join key `ISTAT_CODE`, CRS, the H2-H4 class strings, what the data is not for

3

## Inspect each collection

picks five of the 69: one GeoParquet asset each, with provider, license, extent, row count

4

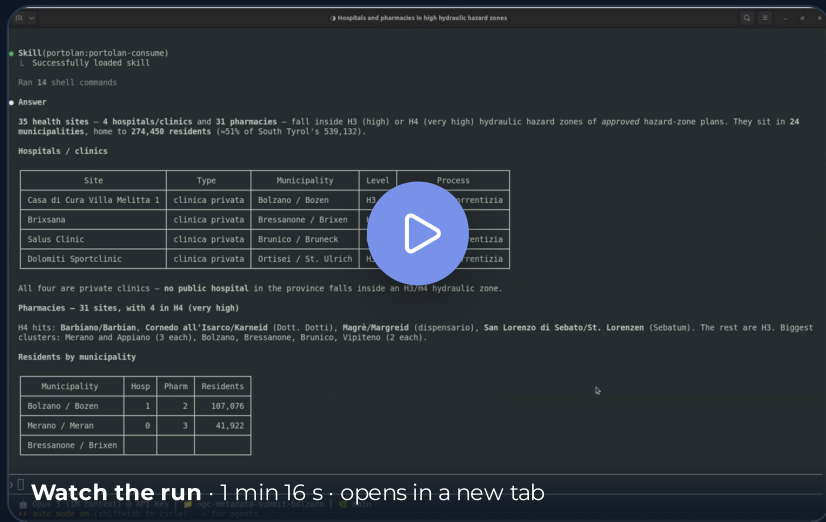
## Plan a DuckDB query

the model plans and explains; DuckDB computes, reading only the row groups it needs

5

## Report

method, exact URLs and query, producer, license, limitations



```
• Skill(portolan:portolan-consume)
  ↳ Successfully loaded skill

Run 14 shell commands

• Answer

35 health sites – 4 hospitals/clinics and 31 pharmacies – fall inside H3 (high) or H4 (very high) hydraulic hazard zones of approved hazard-zone plans. They sit in 24 municipalities, home to 274,450 residents (~51% of South Tyrol's 539,132).

Hospitals / clinics
```

| Site                         | Type            | Municipality         | Level | Process     |
|------------------------------|-----------------|----------------------|-------|-------------|
| Casa di Cura Villa Melitta 1 | clinica privata | Bolzano / Bozen      | H3    | Preventizia |
| Brixiana                     | clinica privata | Bressanone / Brixen  | H3    | Preventizia |
| Salus Clinic                 | clinica privata | Brunico / Bruneck    | H3    | Preventizia |
| Dolomiti Sportclinic         | clinica privata | Ortisei / St. Ulrich | H3    | Preventizia |

```
All four are private clinics – no public hospital in the province falls inside an H3/H4 hydraulic zone.

Pharmacies – 31 sites, with 4 in H4 (very high)

H4 hits: Barbiano/Barbian, Cornedo all'Isarco/Karneid (Dott. Dotti), Magre/Margreid (dispensario), San Lorenzo di Sebato/St. Lorenzen (Sebatum). The rest are H3. Biggest clusters: Merano and Appiano (3 each), Bolzano, Bressanone, Brunico, Vipiteno (2 each).

Residents by municipality
```

| Municipality        | Hosp | Pharm | Residents |
|---------------------|------|-------|-----------|
| Bolzano / Bozen     | 1    | 2     | 107,076   |
| Merano / Meran      | 0    | 3     | 41,922    |
| Bressanone / Brixen |      |       |           |

Watch the run · 1 min 16 s · opens in a new tab

Every step consumed something the publisher wrote down. Nothing was guessed. That is the operational meaning of AI-ready metadata.

Live at the demo desk: ask the agent *your* question on the South Tyrol catalog and watch it read the metadata before it answers.

# The skills: the know-how that made both stories run

## STORY 1 · PUBLISHING

- `portolan-bootstrap` — from a WFS, an Esri service, a portal or a folder to a documented, validated, published catalog
- `portolan-cli` — init, add, check, push, sync, conversion
- `portolan-thumbnails` — framed, checked thumbnails over a basemap
- `portolan-migrate` — bring an existing catalog up to the spec without rebuilding it
- `git-backed-catalog` · `sourcecoop` · `register-catalog` — versioned metadata, hosting, the registry pull request

## STORY 2 · CONSUMING

- `reading-portolan` — the analyst's skill: navigate the STAC tree, query GeoParquet with DuckDB, join across collections, map it with PMTiles, MapLibre or deck.gl, report with sources
- `portolan-consume` — the on-ramp: detects what the user has installed (DuckDB, GeoPandas, rioxarray, rasterio) and shows how to read the GeoParquet and COG assets with those tools
- `report-catalog-issue` — a wrong licence or a broken link becomes an issue on the registry, from the agent

Plain `SKILL.md` files in the open **Agent Skills** format: the same know-how works in Claude Code, Gemini CLI and other agents. Ten skills, one repository, Apache-2.0. **The spec says what a good catalog is; the skills encode how to build and use one.**

# Lesson 1 of 3 • Discovery is the solved half. Evaluability is the gap.

WHAT A GOOD STAC CATALOG ALREADY GIVES YOU

Found. Crawled. Opened.

WHAT PEOPLE AND AGENTS STILL LACK

Is this dataset *for* my question? Where is it weak? How wrong can it be?

ONE SENTENCE FROM A REAL CATALOG (FIELDS OF THE WORLD)

A field polygon "is a *remote-sensing field unit*, **not** a cadastral/legal parcel. This is not a land-tenure product."

No accuracy figure prevents that misuse. One sentence of scope does.

Source: Fields of the World, global field-boundary dataset documentation (fieldsoftheworld, CC BY 4.0), as quoted in the Portolan documentation best practices.

AI-ready = documented limitations, quantified uncertainty, named biases — **as data where possible** (a confidence column, a quality mask), not buried in prose. Expertise that otherwise lives only in the heads of domain experts.

WHERE A LIMITATION LIVES IN A PORTOLAN CATALOG

`known_issues:`

in `metadata.yaml`, written once by the publisher



`## Known Issues`

in `README.md`, for people



`## Data quality & usage notes`

in `AGENTS.md`, for agents



`confidence` column

as data, where the limitation is per row

# Lesson 2 of 3 · Two audiences, two files, one subject

ONE COLLECTION · THREE ENTRANCES



THE SAME PUBLISHED ASSETS

GeoParquet PMTiles · styles · thumbnail · original source

README.md helps a person decide whether to trust the data. AGENTS.md helps an agent that already committed to using it get the query right the first time. Both generated from one source.

# Lesson 3 of 3 • Be strict, and let a machine hold the line

## WHY SO PRESCRIPTIVE

An agent can only rely on what is *required*. Every MAY in a specification is a branch every consumer has to write.

- GeoParquet without bbox columns and spatial ordering: spatial queries read the whole file
- a bucket without CORS: unusable from a browser
- an empty `providers` list: the prose looks fine, every machine fails

## WHAT THE MACHINE HOLDS • SPEC v0.2.0

128

normative  
requirements

105

checked  
deterministically by  
`rashid`

23

stay with the  
publisher's judgment

MUST → failure, SHOULD → warning, JSON out. A city's catalog passes the same validator a planetary archive passes.

**Conformance is a floor.** "You can have perfectly FAIR, utterly useless data." Above pass/fail, a grader scores usability from A+ to F, and weights the machine contract equally with what a browser shows.

A metadata quality policy only sticks when a machine can check it.



# Honestly unfinished: trust and provenance



How should **authority** be signalled cryptographically, not just declared in a providers list?



What does **trust** mean when the consumer is an agent acting unattended?



How does a **mirror** stay verifiably faithful to its source?

Today: every collection names producer, licensor, processor and host; official or mirror is derived from that; a registry of ~20 independently hosted catalogs, plain JSON in git. All declarative. The questions above map onto the OGC Testbed on Trusted Data and Systems.

**Public since 2 September 2026.** Early adopters wanted; breaking changes still expected. First goal: ~100 reference catalogs, then a stable v1.0 CLI.

# Questions? Everything is open and one pull request away.

## PROJECT LINKS

CLICK ANY CARD

WEBSITE

[portolan-sdi.org](https://portolan-sdi.org)



ALL PROJECTS

[github.com/portolan-sdi](https://github.com/portolan-sdi)



SPECIFICATION

[portolan-spec](https://portolan-spec)



PUBLISHER CLI

[portolan-cli](https://portolan-cli)



VALIDATOR

[rashid](https://rashid)



AGENT SKILLS

[portolan-skills](https://portolan-skills)



PUBLIC REGISTRY

[portolan-registry](https://portolan-registry)



CATALOG BROWSER

[browser.portolan-sdi.org](https://browser.portolan-sdi.org)



## THIS DECK



cayetanobv.github.io

ogc-metadata-summit-bolzano/#/18

SCAN · CLICK · SHARE

# Appendix 1 • Why "Portolan"



Portolan chart of the Mediterranean and the Black Sea, Battista Agnese, 1550. Bibliothèque nationale de France, via Wikimedia Commons (public domain).

Portolan charts were among the earliest **practical** navigational maps: not theoretical pictures of the world but working tools, built from sailors' observations, continuously refined, and shared across ports and nations.

- **Decentralised** — made and improved by many hands
- **Interoperable** — readable wherever a ship went
- **Critical infrastructure** — for trade, for safety, for sovereignty

**The project takes its name from that tradition. Practical rather than academic; built from data in open formats rather than drawings; designed for sharing across organisations, clouds and borders.**

## Appendix 2 • ISO 19115 / INSPIRE records as inputs

### ISO IN

`portolan extract wfs` reads the ISO 19139 record over CSW and seeds title, abstract, keywords, license, contact, lineage, dates.

### ISO ALONGSIDE

The record travels with the data as an asset with `roles:`  
`["metadata", "iso-19115"]` and a typed `describedby` link to the catalogue that owns it.

### GEODCAT-AP OUT

Generated from the same source as a sibling representation, so open-data portals can harvest it.  
Roadmap, not shipped.

**The same pattern swisstopo and the CEOS STAC best practices already follow. There is still no ISO 19115 STAC extension — an open question for this room.**

## Appendix 2 • How an ISO record rides in a Portolan collection

```
"assets": {
  "metadata": {
    "href": "./iso19115.xml",
    "type": "application/vnd.iso.19139+xml",
    "title": "ISO 19115 record, BRK Bestuurlijke Gebieden (Nationaal Georegister)",
    "roles": ["metadata", "iso-19115"],
    "file:size": 40942, "file:checksum": "1220..."
  }
},
"links": [
  {"rel": "describedby", "href": "./README.md", "type": "text/markdown"},
  {"rel": "describedby",
   "href": "https://www.nationaalgeoregister.nl/geonetwork/srv/api/records/208bc283-.../formatters/xml",
   "type": "application/vnd.iso.19139+xml", "title": "ISO 19115 record – authoritative"},
  {"rel": "via", "href": "https://www.pdok.nl/...", "type": "text/html", "title": "Original source (PDOK)"}
]
```

**Asset = pinned copy with checksum and mirror date. Link = live authoritative record. If they disagree, the link wins and the asset tells you how old the copy is.**